

Chapter 9

When Leaders Derail

The Challenge

Nobody likes to think about career derailment, the term used to describe the involuntary cessation of a once advancing career. It feels like a train wreck for the individuals who derail and it's costly for organizations as well. The irony is that this wreckage sometimes represents one of the most significant development experiences for leaders.¹ Over the last three decades, I-O psychologists have learned a lot about the causes of derailment, how leaders can prevent derailment, and what they can do to get back on track when things go wrong. In this chapter, we'll discuss some of these key findings and how you can use this information to manage around your own weaknesses, help your direct reports, and build an organization that is derailment-resistant.

The Bottom Line

The Dynamics of Derailment

Derailment is most likely to strike during times of transition – a new boss, a new job, or a significant shift in the business environment.² Old strategies no longer work and past strengths can become weaknesses in the new conditions. For example, imagine the leader who moves from a staff finance position, where company-wide solutions are developed through collaboration and consensus, to a line

leadership position in sales, where daily execution is what matters most. Suddenly, those collaboration skills and the inclination to look for shared group solutions become a liability. To survive, the leader is going to need to give up some of the very things that made him or her successful in the previous role, and is going to have to learn a whole new set of skills that have not been tested before.

But derailment doesn't only happen during a job change. The job can sometimes change underneath the leader. A new boss can be assigned with different priorities and values. Maybe the new boss no longer values what the leader brings. Maybe he or she is just a bad leader. Maybe the business environment changes around the leader. Imagine a leader whose core capabilities have centered on disciplined operational excellence going into an entrepreneurial environment requiring innovation and change. The old strategies won't work anymore, and unless the leader figures out how to develop new ones or leverages other people, he or she will be in trouble.

Why Leaders Derail: The 10 Deadly Sins

Research in I-O psychology suggests that the leading causes of derailment are poor performance, a failure to adapt to change, arrogance, unrecognized blind spots, the failure to build a strong team, the failure to build a network, poor working relationships, the inclination to avoid stretch assignments, unethical behavior, and just plain bad luck.³ These 10 common causes of derailment are described in more detail in the box at the end of the chapter, which outlines some strategies to prevent them from becoming a problem for you.

Getting Over a Derailment Will Take Time

Derailing in your career is never easy, especially when it wasn't your fault. The anger and sense of loss take a long time to subside. Sometimes you never get over it. Finding your part in the story is hard work. It's easy to blame yourself for too much or to overlook the role that you did play. In these moments, it's important to get outside perspectives – people who you trust and who can give you honest, constructive feedback. It also means asking people who might not be

your biggest fans to give you their feedback. You still get to decide what you want to own and what you want to reject, but you need to listen first. Many of the leaders we have talked to over the years have never fully gotten over derailments in their careers. Some find themselves still driven by past failures and injustices. The ones most at peace are the leaders who have done the hard work to think through past situations and to come to terms with what was unfair and unjust, the role they played, and how they want to live their lives in the future.

Stay Open to Learning

The secret to both the prevention of derailment and recovery from derailment is being open to learning. It requires asking your manager, peers, employees, and customers for candid feedback. It means asking yourself, “What truth am I blurring?” You may find some things that you just have to accept (e.g., you are good at execution but will always struggle with long-term planning). There will be other things that you can change but it will take a lot of work (e.g., you are hard-driving and abrasive or you naturally want to make everyone happy). And there may be other things that require you to put in the time to learn them (e.g., you need to learn to build and defend your budget). Sometimes learning means you finally come to terms with who you are, accept it, and decide what you are going to do with it from here.

Derailment Isn't Always Bad

Derailment can be an important time of self-reflection, for clarifying the things that really matter to you, for discovering your leadership principles and for identifying what you stand for. It may teach you some things about yourself that you didn't want to know. Derailment can help some leaders confront just how far from their values they have strayed. It's a chance to ask yourself the questions that will make you a better leader on the other side. When leaders plateau in their careers – and a narrowing pyramid means that almost all leaders eventually do – it can propel them to consider the role they play in other people's lives, and the contribution (and legacy) they want to

leave in their current job. For some leaders, it's the only way to break the habit of defining their value based on their job and find their value elsewhere. The experience of being derailed often forces leaders to take stock of changing goals and priorities, and gives them a chance to be a different kind of person.

Taking Action

Figure Out What Will Get in the Way of Your Success

Consider your own strengths and weaknesses. Assess yourself against the leading causes of derailment in the “10 Deadly Sins” box. Use the reflection questions below to identify the factors that are most likely to trip you up.

Find your Achilles' heel. Think about the future career paths you would like to pursue. Get specific. What do you want to do in five years time? Identify the derailers that could get in the way. Identify the aspects about your personality, style, abilities, or proclivities that you know will become an issue. Set aside time to answer the following question, “Given that I eventually want to _____, what is it about me that will get in the way?”

Learn from the past. Consider a career setback that you have experienced in the past. Think back on the lessons that you took away from that experience. If a younger leader were going through a similar experience, what advice would you give him or her? Thinking back on the experience, how have you changed and become a better leader as a result? What were some red flags you missed? What, if anything, could you have done differently?

Discover your strengths (or weaknesses?). Write down your five greatest strengths as a leader. Because every strength can become a weakness,⁴ identify how each of your strengths could get you into trouble. For example, finance and budgets may be particularly easy for you, but you get nervous and tentative when decisions need to be made in emerging markets where data isn't available. Maybe you pick things up quickly and get frustrated in meetings when people can't

keep up with you. Walk through each of your strengths and identify situations where they could trip you up and become liabilities. Look especially for times when you will be tempted to rely too heavily on your strengths, ignoring other alternatives. This is likely to be especially problematic when you are under stress and are tempted to revert to the skills that always worked before! For each of these weaknesses, identify how you can get “good enough” or design a support system to compensate for the weakness.⁵

Reevaluate your priorities. Derailment is a great time to evaluate yourself and your values. If you are stagnating or plateauing in your career, it is a time to consider the things that are most important to you. Picture yourself in 20 years – older, humbler and wiser. Imagine this future-you comes back to give you some advice. What would the future-you say? If a younger leader were going through this experience, what advice would you give him or her? If advancing beyond your current position is not possible in the foreseeable future, what contributions can you make right where you are? What else is important in your life right now? What can you do, inside or outside of work, to stretch and challenge yourself?

Create Your Own “Early Warning System”

Find ways to guard against derailment. Make sure you sit down with your boss and clearly define “success” in your job. Don’t leave it to chance. Define the explicit and implicit measures that will be used to assess your effectiveness. If your manager thinks you have done poorly or failed, ask your boss to clearly define what he or she will need to see to conclude that you are performing better in the future. Come to a joint agreement in writing if possible. Establish milestones along the way that will help you both determine if you are on track. Ask the people around you to give you feedback about how you are doing. Don’t expect that they will seek you out when they see a problem. Ask them directly how you are doing and to provide feedback on any changes they have observed. Take advantage of any feedback systems that are already in place to assess your ongoing performance, including one-on-one meetings with your boss, leadership assessments like 360-degree feedback, and of course your business metrics.

Build a Derailment-Resistant Organization

If you are a senior organizational leader and/or the HR professional in charge of talent management in your organization, you also are responsible for creating “early warning” systems in the organizations that will allow people to detect problems and make corrections before it’s too late. For example, some organizations use structured onboarding processes to help new leaders understand the challenges they will face in their new jobs. For established leaders, rigorous performance management systems or 360-degree feedback systems can give managers feedback about how they are being perceived by others. When senior leaders are ready to make particularly significant moves in their careers, many companies like Microsoft or IBM will interview peers, senior leaders, and their direct reports and use the information to provide in-depth feedback and coaching to the leaders. Several other processes that are discussed later in this book can play a critical role in helping leaders detect problems and self-correct before it’s too late (e.g., mentoring, networking, performance management, development conversations, transition management).

Create a culture where “success” is defined more broadly than by just management promotions. For example, some organizations have created career paths for technical employees that provide advancement opportunities so management is reserved for people who want to be leaders. A derailment-resistant culture is one that recognizes the value of employees at every level in the company who are making great contributions. It is one that challenges people to find jobs they enjoy, where they can have an impact and serve others.

Finding ways to build a derailment-resistant culture and to prevent derailment *before* it happens is smart business! Carefully examine individual cases of derailment – what were the contributing individual and organizational factors? Figure out if it really was the person. Sometimes it’s time to stop blaming people and to figure out what’s broken in the system.

To Learn More

Kovach, B. E. (1989). Successful derailment: What fast-trackers can learn while they’re off the track. *Organizational Dynamics*, 18(2), 33–47.

Lombardo, M. M., & Eichinger, R. W. (1989). *Preventing derailment: What to do before it's too late*. Greensboro, NC: Center for Creative Leadership.

McCall, M. W., & Lombardo, M. M. (1983). *Off the track: Why and how successful executives get derailed* (Tech. Rep. No. 21). Greensboro, NC: Center for Creative Leadership.

Van Velsor, E., & Leslie, J. B. (1995). Why executives derail: Perspectives across time and cultures. *Academy of Management Executive*, 9(4), 62–72.

Good to Know:
The 10 Deadly Sins

The 10 deadly sins listed below are by no means inclusive of all of the possible causes of derailment, but they comprise some of the most common problems that can trip leaders up.⁶ Every company is likely to have some unique ones they may want to add. The readings suggested in this chapter provide a deeper discussion of common causes of derailment and additional suggestions about preventing derailment in your career.

1. Poor performance. There are many causes of poor performance. Sometimes leaders don't take the time that's needed to clearly define with their boss the criteria for "success" in their current assignment. Sometimes they are simply a bad match for the job and don't have the

required skills. Some leaders may be so focused on promotion to the next job that they fail to invest the energy and hard work that is needed to succeed in their current assignment. To prevent this from happening to you, focus on succeeding in your current job before you consider future career opportunities. Clearly establish the top priorities in your job and the metrics that will be used to assess your progress. Make sure that you and your immediate manager agree to this, and ensure these are the same criteria that are important to the other key decision makers in your organization. You may have to take the lead, proactively setting expectations about what is realistic. Solicit feedback from the people around you to assess how you are doing. If you are struggling, admit it to yourself

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and find ways to work with your manager and others to turn things around.

2. Failure to adapt. Leaders are in the greatest danger of derailment during times of transition, including promotions to a new job, lateral moves to a new business group, or moves to a new company. But the leader doesn't have to move for transitions to be a factor. Leaders derail just as often when the environment changes around them and they don't adapt to the change (e.g., a new boss, a change in the market, or a reorganization). To increase your adaptability, assume that change is the rule rather than the exception; anticipate it and actively seek feedback from others about the company and about yourself so you can adapt. Include the exercises discussed in this book in your approach to your job, focusing special attention on the chapters in Parts II and III and chapter 19 on transitions.

3. Arrogance. Leaders are often called upon to take stands and drive changes that other people won't always like. Leadership isn't a popularity contest, but sometimes there is a very fine line between self-confidence and arrogance. Leaders who try to make everyone happy never will, but

leaders who ignore feedback can get blindsided. The media is filled with stories every year about arrogant leaders who drift into serious ethics problems. To guard against arrogance, test yourself at the most basic level: Do you consider yourself better and more valuable than the other people in your organization? Consider how you react and behave under pressure: Do people come to you with bad news? Are you short with people, defensive, abrasive, abusive? Don't try to answer these questions alone. You will need external perspectives. Identify people you trust at work and at home (people who will give you constructive feedback).

4. Blind spots. Blind spots can include weaknesses. They can also be an overreliance on strengths.⁷ For example, the marketing leader who becomes a general manager will be tempted to see everything as a marketing issue, failing to recognize equally important and valid perspectives that other disciplines bring to the table. To avoid blind spots, surround yourself with a diverse group of people and proactively solicit their feedback. Take time to ask yourself and the people around you, "What am I missing?"

5. Failure to build a strong team. Leaders, by definition,

succeed or fail through others, so failing to build a strong team can be a fatal error for a manager. Some leaders fail to build a strong team because, deep down, they don't really want to be a leader. They want the title, but aren't interested in the job.

Other leaders fail because they staff their team with weak talent or build a team of people who are just like themselves. Some leaders build a team where team members compete instead of complementing each other. Other leaders fail to create the conditions that will make the team successful. Building a strong team is complicated, hard work, and a never-ending process. The endnotes contain suggested readings to help you build strong, robust teams.⁸

6. Failure to build a network.

Leaders can derail, especially in large organizations, if they fail to build a strong network across the company. Leaders with weak networks are more likely to derail because their careers become tied too closely to a single senior leader. They are limited in their ability to draw on people. Their names are less likely to come up when new opportunities emerge, and they have fewer people who know and can advocate for them. Because they also tend to be less aware of organizational politics, they are more likely to get

caught in turf battles and are less able to frame their work in ways that will be accepted. Chapter 13 provides strategies that leaders can use to strengthen their networks.

7. Poor working relationships.

Leaders get things done through other people. For some leaders, what starts out as a drive for results can become abrasive and arrogant. Over time, people quit coming to the leader with feedback or bad news.

Eventually, the leader self-destructs or, worse, people actively sabotage the leader.

Equally dangerous is the leader who tries to please everyone.⁹

Leaders wouldn't be doing their jobs if they tried to make everyone happy, but there are some behaviors that are never

wrong: respect for others, openness to feedback, integrity, humility, honesty, and wanting the best for others. Consider your working relations with the people around you. Are you honest? Are you approachable? Do you want the best for others? Do people trust you? Improving interpersonal skills is tough work. Find a mentor who has struggled with the issues and get his or her advice. Consider working with an executive coach. Recognize that change will take a long time, and then look for some small changes you can make today!

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8. Avoiding stretch assignments. Stretch assignments are often double-edged swords. Leaders need to put themselves in stretch positions to discover, develop, and refine their leadership potential. Avoiding them will likely decrease future promotion opportunities. After all, when tough choices have to be made, companies will tend to choose leaders who have proven themselves in the fire. However, there are equally good reasons to avoid stretch positions. They are high risk and people fail in them. Early failures can follow leaders. There may also be personal reasons (e.g., family or health issues) for why you might not take on stretch assignments. So, ask yourself the following questions: In your career, what do you value most? What is the right choice for you at this stage in your life? What is the right stretch for you?

9. Unethical behavior. Unethical behavior can destroy leaders and the companies they lead. To prevent getting in trouble, consider the choices you make every day in the gray areas of your business. Make sure you know what your legal and ethical responsibilities are in your industry, in your role as a

manager, and as an employee of the company. Then ask yourself, “Would I feel comfortable if this action was published on the front page of the paper tomorrow morning?” If it doesn’t feel right, don’t do it. Ask someone! And remember, that the truth almost always comes out – eventually.

10. Bad luck. Sometimes derailment is simply being in the wrong place at the wrong time – you get caught in company politics, you get a new boss who’s truly awful, you are given an impossible assignment, the market changes, and your performance suffers. So it’s time to pick up the pieces, figure out a way to let the anger go, and move on. When you can finally think straight, don’t miss the chance to consider signals you may have missed or the role that you may have inadvertently played. Everybody knows leaders who blamed everyone but themselves. Don’t let that leader be you. So, if bad luck strikes, ask the people to share their thoughts. Be willing to listen without being defensive. They may be wrong, but their perceptions can provide you some valuable insights. Finally, find people who have faced similar situations.